

Linguistic identity politics in West Middle Iranian

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Initial Questions

- ▶ The West Middle Iranian languages, Middle Persian and Parthian, are linguistically very close, and were likely mutually intelligible.
- ▶ Nevertheless, a small number of multilingual royal inscriptions, all 3rd century CE, exist in MP-Pth. or MP-Pth.-Gk.

⇒ **What are the reasons for this monumental multilingualism?**

- ▶ Parallels exist in Classical Greece, particularly for Attic and Ionic bilingual inscriptions.
- ▶ In this case, the question of the ties between a language (variety) and a (local/historical) identity and/or historico-political function are clearly at play.

⇒ **Hypothesis:**

The existence of MP-Pth. multilingual inscriptions is related to the initial attempt at creating/retaining/pretending at a Parthian identity at a politically significant level.

Structure

An initial digression

West Middle Iranian: background

West Middle Iranian: multilingual inscriptions

Greek: Attic and Ionic

Inscriptions II

Looking ahead

But first: a multilingual digression



But first: a multilingual digression



But first: a multilingual digression



But first: a multilingual digression



⇒ multilingualism is locally dependent

More digression



More digression



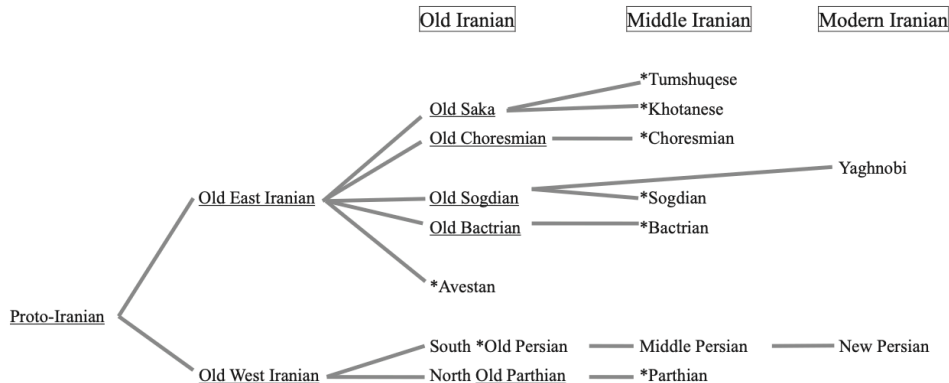
⇒ multilingualism is audience-dependent

Last digression



⇒ multilingualism is identity-dependent
(and can go wrong)

West Middle Iranian: tree



(YOSHIDA 2018)

NB there is good reason to postulate a third West Middle Iranian language (KORN AND OLSEN

West Middle Iranian: differences

Phonology

- ▶ OIr. *b, *d, *g > Pth. /β, δ, γ/, MP /w, y, y/
bay vs *bay* ‘god’, cp. Arm. *sparapēt* vs *spayapēt*
- ▶ OIr. *č, ĵ > Pth. /ž/, MP /z/
až vs *az* ‘from’
- ▶ OIr. *z > Pth. /z/, MP /d/
zard vs *dil* ‘heart’
- ▶ OIr. *tr > Pth. /hr/, MP /s/
puhr vs *pūs* ‘son’
- ▶ ...

Morphology & Syntax

- ▶ differences in periphrastic tenses
awestād ahēnd vs *nihād hēnd* ‘have made stand’
- ▶ use of *ezāfe*-marking
- ▶ ...

Lexis

- ▶ *puhrēpuhr* vs *nab* ‘grandson’
- ▶ *wāxt* vs *guft* ‘said’
- ▶ ...

West Middle Iranian: attestations

- ▶ [Pth.] Nisa ostraca (1st c. BCE)
- ▶ [Pth.] Awroman parchment
- ▶ [Pth.] Dura-Europos documents
- ▶ [both] coin legends, seals
- ▶ [both] small number of Arsacid and Sasanian inscriptions (mid-3rd to late 4th cc.)
- ▶ [both] *Nebenüberlieferung* (Armenian, Georgian, Greek)
- ▶ [both] (much later) Manichaean documents

The pre-Manichaean attestations are less numerous and of a lesser complexity and length.
The inscriptions further frequently contain Aramaic-based ideograms.

NB There are no Parthian inscriptions from the Arsacid Empire; Aramaic and Greek were used.

WMIr. multilingual inscriptions

There are seven multilingual inscriptions (BACK 1978).

Trilingual: Middle Persian – Parthian – Greek

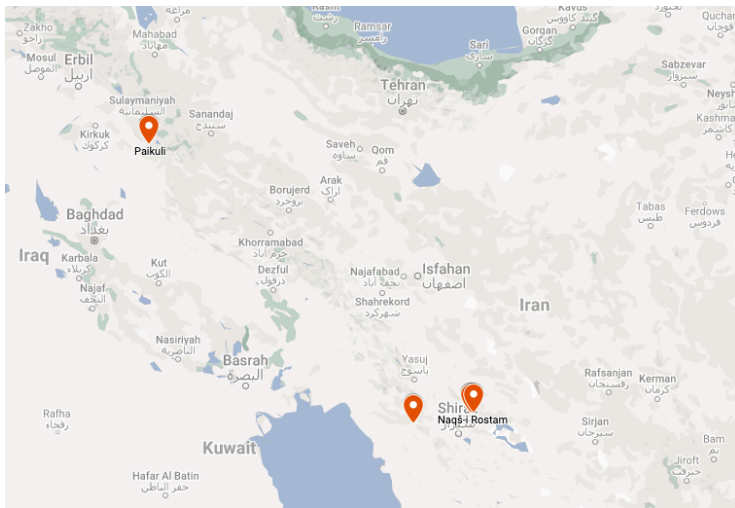
- ▶ Ardašir at Naqš-i Rostam (ANRm-a)
- ▶ Ardašir (as Ahuramazda) at Naqš-i Rostam (ANRm-b)
- ▶ Šābuhr I at Naqš-i Rājab (ŠNRb)
- ▶ Šābuhr I on the Ka'ba-i Zardošt (ŠKZ, *Res Gestae Divi Saporis*)

Bilingual: Middle Persian – Parthian

- ▶ Šābuhr I at Hājjīābād (ŠH) / Tang-i Borāq (ŠTBq)
- ▶ Dedication to Šābuhr I at Bīšāpūr (ŠVŠ)
- ▶ Narseh at Paikuli (HUMBACH AND SKJÆRVØ 1983)

ANRm-a & b and ŠNRb are very short; ŠH/ŠTBq and ŠVŠ a little more than a dozen lines; ŠKZ and Paikuli significantly longer, but partly lacunary in one language.

A map



A short trilingual: ANRm-a

- (1) [MP] *ptkr-y ZNḤ mzdysn bg-y 'rthštr MLK'-n MLK' 'yr'n MNW ctr-y MN yzt'n BRḤ*
[Pth.] *ptkr ZNḤ mzdysn 'LH' 'rthštr MLKYN MLK' 'yr'n MNW šyhr MN y'ztn BRY*
bg-y p'pk-y MLK'
'LH' p'pk MLK'

TOYTO TO ΠΡΟCΩΠΙΟΝ ΜΑCΔΑCΝΟY ΘΕΟY ΑΡΤΑΞΕΑΡΟY ΒΑCΙΛΕΩC ΒΑCΙΛΕΩΝ
ΑΡΙΑΝΩΝ ΕΚ ΓΕΝΟYC ΘΕΩΝ ΥΙΟY ΘΕΟY ΠΑΠΑΚΟY ΒΑCΙΛΕΩC

“This is the image of [His] Mazdayasnean Majesty Ardašir, King of Kings of Ērān, who [is]
from divine lineage, son of [His] Majesty King Pāpak.”

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from divine lineage, son of [His] Majesty King Pāpak.”

A long trilingual: ŠKZ

(2) Pth.

(§1) Az, mazdēzn bay
Šābuhr, šāhān šāh Ērān ud
Anērān, kē čīhr až yazdān,
puhr mazdēzn bay Ardašīr,
šāhān šāh Erān, kē čīhr až
yazdān, puhrēpuhr bay
Pābag šāh, Erānsahr
xwadāy ahēm

...

(§5) Ud im āwand šahr ud
šahrδār ud pādgošbān harw
amā pad bāž ud bandagīf
avestād ahēnd

MP

(§1) [An, maz]dēsn bay
[Šābuhr, šāhān šāh Ērān ud
Anērān, kē čīhr az yazdān,
pus mazdēsn bay Ardašīr,
šāhān šāh Ērān, kē čīhr az
yazdān, nab bay
Pābag šāh, Ērānšahr
x^wadāy hēm]

...

(§5) [U-n ēn and šahr ud
šahryār ud pāygošbān harw
pad bāz ud bandagīh nihād
hēnd]

Gk.

(§1) ἐγὼ μασδαασνης θεὸς
Σαπώρης, βασιλεὺς βασιλέων
Ἀριανῶν καὶ Ἀναριανῶν, ἐκ
γένους θεῶν, υἱὸς μασδαασνου
θεοῦ Ἀρταξάρου, βασιλέως
βασιλέων, Ἀριανῶν, ἐκ γένους
θεῶν, ἑγγονος θεοῦ Παπάκον
βασιλέως τοῦ Ἀριανῶν ἔθνου[ς
κύριός εἰμι]

...

(§5) καὶ ταῦτα τὰ τοσαῦτα
ἔθνη καὶ τοὺς δέσποτας τῶν
ἔθνων τῶν ἐκ παντὸς μέρους
πάντας ἡμεῖν [εἰς φόρους καὶ]
δουλείαν ἐστήσαμεν

A long trilingual: ŠKZ

(2) Pth.

(§1) **Az**, mazdēzn bay
Šābuhr, šāhān šāh Ērān ud
Anērān, kē čīhr až yazdān,
puhr mazdēzn bay Ardašīr,
šāhān šāh Ērān, kē čīhr až
yazdān, **puhrēpuhr** bay
Pābag šāh, Erānsahr
xwadāy ahēm

...

(§5) **Ud im āwand** šahr ud
šahr**δār** ud pā**dgōsbān** harw
amā pad bā**ž** ud bandagī**f**
awestād ahēnd

MP

(§1) [An, maz]dēsn bay
[Šābuhr, šāhān šāh Ērān ud
Anērān, kē čīhr az yazdān,
pus mazdēsn bay Ardašīr,
šāhān šāh Ērān, kē čīhr az
yazdān, nab bay
Pābag šāh, Ērānšahr
x^wadāy hēm]

...

(§5) [U-n ēn and šahr ud
šahryār ud pāy**gōsbān** harw
pad bāz ud bandagīh nihād
hēnd]

Transl.

(§1) I, [His] Mazdayasnean
Majesty Šābuhr, King of Kings
of Ērān and Not-Ērān, whose is
from divine lineage, son of
[his] Mazdayasnean Majesty
Ardašīr, King of Kings of Ērān,
whose is from divine lineage,
grandson of [His] Majesty
Pābag, the King, [I] am Lord of
Ērānšahr

...

(§5) And these numerous lands
and governors and nobles, all
[of them] we have made
tributaries and dependents

Comparison

- ▶ The Parthian and Middle Persian versions differ, as expected, in certain phonological and, at times, morphological and lexical details.
 - ▶ While there is no certainty, it seems highly plausible that the two languages would have been mutually intelligible (SUNDERMANN 1989:106, 110; DURKIN-MEISTERERNST 2014:1; MEYER 2023:56–7).
- ⇒ So, why include both – and why Greek?

Comparison

- ▶ The Parthian and Middle Persian versions differ, as expected, in certain phonological and, at times, morphological and lexical details.
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- ⇒ So, why include both – and why Greek?
- ▶ Given the triumphal(ist) character of the (main) inscriptions, a particular communicative goal and audience must be assumed.
 - ▶ Equally, there is likely to be a chronological component, since later inscriptions are monolingual, e.g. those of the *mōbed* Kardīr (KSM,KNRm, KKZ, KNRb), of the kings Narseh (NVŠ), Šābuhr II (ŠTBn-I, ŠPs-I) and Šābuhr III (ŠTBn-II), and of Mihr-Narseh, the *wuzurg framadār* (MNFd)

Historical Perspective

*This multilingual view of the empire was not lost to the Sasanians either and we see that the early Sasanian royal inscriptions provide bilingual or trilingual testimonies, **reminding us of the Achaemenid inscriptions**. However, now the dominant language along Middle Persian was the language of the preceding dynasty, i.e., Parthian and Greek. Greek had remained the language of science and knowledge from India to the Mediterranean basin for centuries. Ardaxšīr I and his son Šābuhr I both used this trilingual mode of writing, as the Achaemenids had done with other languages. **Middle Persian was becoming the dominant language** at the heart of the empire which gives us certain insights into the linguistic and cultural preoccupation of the Sasanians. [...]*

***Kerdīr only had his inscription carved in Middle Persian in the third century CE which may be an indication of the change in not only linguistic taste, but a purposeful reaction to foreign languages and ideas.** [...] we can gain some ideas about the religious and imperial policies in relation to language and culture. Middle Persian was perhaps the language used by the Persian Zoroastrians, and Kerdīr did not need to communicate in any other language. **The King of Kings, however, had to convey his message to all of his people**, whether Persian Zoroastrians, Parthian soldiers and the nobility in the court, or the Greek prisoners and colonists of old who were phihellen.*

(DARYAEE 2009:99–100; cf. HUYSE 2014:176–7)

Back to the hypothesis

- ▶ no meaningfully established Parthian language identity in the public domain before the Sasanian inscriptions – role of coins, etc. limited
- ⇒ innovative use of Parthian as an attempt at appeasement / continuity / legitimacy?
 - ▶ ‘hostile takeover’ from Arsacids by Sasanians
 - ▶ continue to rely on Parthian nobles, vassal kingdoms
 - ▶ notion of dynastic and imperial continuity
- ▶ lack of later multilingual inscriptions explained by religious and political tensions with some of the Parthian vassals, decline of their internal status (MEYER 2022)

Greek: Attic and Ionic

Another set of two closely related varieties, both instances of East Greek, with almost identical lexis, and limited morphophonological differences.

Key differences:

- ▶ geography
- ▶ [early] writing conventions
- ▶ [later] literary genre

Phonology

- ▶ treatment of *ā
Att. χώρα, Ion. χώρα ‘space, land, country’
- ▶ *metathesis quantitatum*
Att. βασιλέως, Ion. βασιλήος ‘king (GEN)’
- ▶ contraction of short vowel sequences
Att. γένους, Ion. γένεος ‘race, people (GEN)’
- ▶ ...

Lexis

- ▶ Att. ξύν, Ion. σύν ‘with’
- ▶ ...

A different map



after WOODARD (2008:51)

The Phanodikos stele (IG I³ 1508)

(3) **Ionic**

Φανοδίκο
ἐμὶ τὸρμοκ-
ράτεος τῷ
Προκοννη-
σίου· κρητῆρ-
α δὲ : καὶ ὑποκ-
ρητήριον : κ-
αὶ ἡθμὸν : ἐς π-
ρυτανήιον
ἔδωκεν : Συκε-
εὔσιν.

Attic

Φανοδίκο : εἰμὶ : τῷ *h*-
ερμοκράτος : τῷ Προκο-
νεσίου : καὶ γὰρ : κρατῆρα
κάπιστατον : καὶ *h*εθμ-
ὸν : ἐς πρυτανεῖον : ἔ-
- δοκα : μνῆμα : Σιγεί-
εὔσι :

‘I belong to Phanodikos, the son of Hermokrates, the Prokonnesian; he gave a mixing-bowl, a stand, and a [strainer] to the Sykeeis for their prytaneion.’

‘I belong to Phanodikos, the son of Hermokrates the Prokonnesian. And I gave a mixing-bowl, a stand, and a strainer as a monument to the Sigeueis for their prytaneion.’

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εὔσιν.

Attic

Φανοδίκο : εἰμὶ : τῷ h-
ερμοκράτος : τῷ Προκο-
νεσίο : κἀγὼ : κρατῆρα
κἀπίστατον : καὶ hεθμ-
ὸν : ἐς πρυτανεῖον : ἔ-
- δοκα : μνῆμα : Σιγעי-
εὔσι :

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Political multilingualism

...la transposition dialectale n'était pas tant motivée par la nécessité de se faire comprendre que par la volonté de donner une traduction linguistique à son identité politique.

(MINON 2009:99)

- ▶ historico-political context is key – an Attic-Ionic bilingual in an otherwise Aeolic setting
- ▶ marker to establish the conquerors' identity

Looking ahead

- ▶ The notion of a (linguistic) *identity* is inherently difficult to establish for less well-attested languages.
- ▶ Still, historical contexts and parallels from better-attested languages can help to identify what might be misconstrued as endogenous identity building.
- ▶ The lacunary case of Sasanian multilingual inscriptions, in its context, suggests that the use of Parthian there was *neither* for communicative purposes *nor* for reasons relevant to Parthian speakers (at least no primarily).
- ▶ Rather, it might best be seen as an instance of political / symbolic legitimisation of one dynasty succeeding another.

Thank you for your attention!

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